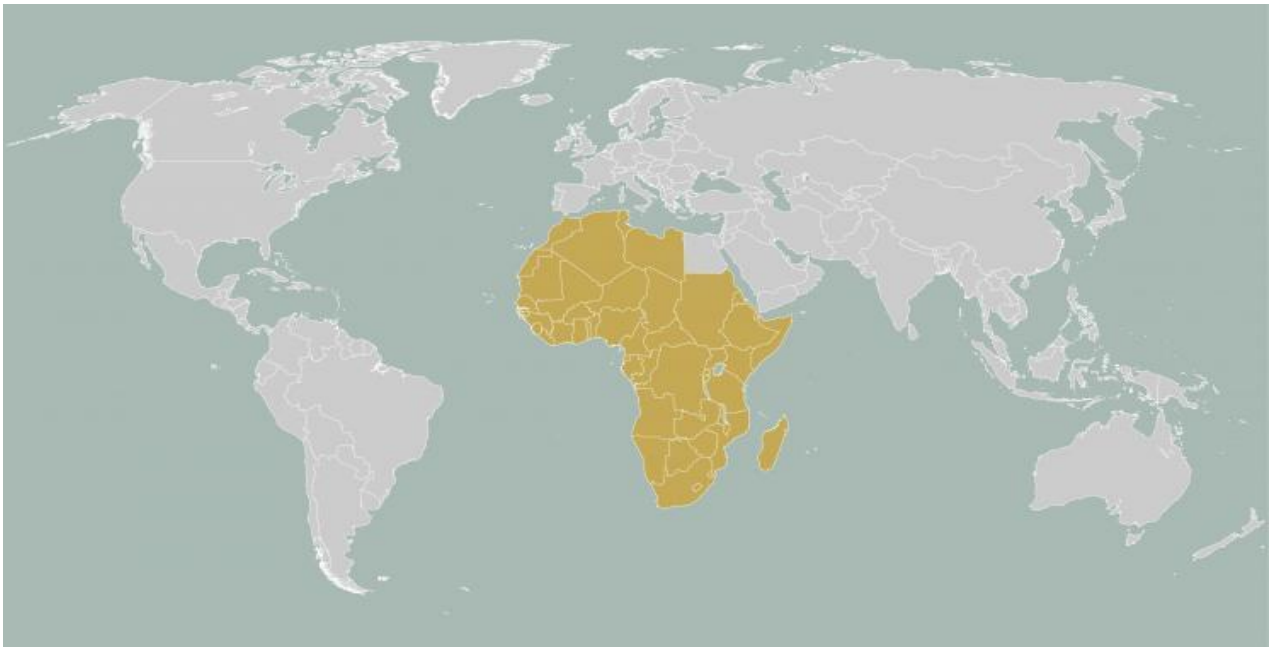
Africa



Africa is the world's second-largest and second-most populous continent. It covers 20% of its land area. With 1.3 billion people as of 2018, it accounts for about 16% of the world's human population.

It has 54 nations and is rich in mineral resources That has attracted nations from across the world since the Middle Ages.

Africa is a continent of growth and opportunities. With the young and fastest growing youth population in the world and considerable natural resources and human capital at its disposal, Africa is poised to be a significant growth factor in the global economy. Presently Africa is being seen as a new growth Pole and there has been a scramble for Africa among the major global powers.

Significance of Africa

1. Africa is home to over half a dozen of the fastest growing countries of this decade such as Rwanda, Senegal, and Tanzania etc. Real GDP in Africa and Sub-Saharan Africa in the past decade has grown by more than twice the rate in 1980s and 90's, making it one of the growth poles of the world.
2. Africa accounts for nearly 17% of the world's population today and is expected to reach 25% in 2050.
3. Africa is among the youngest continent with 60% of population below 25 years and has fastest growing population. Thus, it has huge future market potential.
4. Africa has a population of over one billion with a combined GDP of 2.5 trillion dollars making it Ideal market and investment destination.
5. Africa is resource rich, dominated by commodities like crude oil, gas, pulses and lentils, leather, gold and other metals. This provides for economic Complementarities for both developed and developing economies.

6. The energy resources with Africa is key to the diversification strategy of many developing nations like India and China.
7. The number of countries in Africa make it an important block for voting at platforms like UN and WTO.
8. Africa has emerged as new battleground for major powers like India, China, USA and Europe to increase influence due to its resource richness, economic potential and voting power at global platforms.
9. The instability in Africa due to civil wars external interventions and terrorism has resulted in refugee crisis. This has added another layer to the challenges of geopolitics.
10. Geographically, Africa becomes important due to its location around critical sea lanes like Bab el mandeb and Suez Canal.
11. Since Africa shares its boundary with the Indian Ocean, it is important for the safety of sea lanes of communication.

African Union:

1. African Union, a Union of 55 member states, was founded on 26 May 2001 in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, and launched on 9 July 2002 in Durban, South Africa. It replaced the Organisation for African Unity.
2. The highest decision-making organ is the Assembly of the African Union, made up of all the heads of state or government of member states of the AU.
3. The AU also has a representative body, the Pan-African Parliament, which consists of 265 members elected by the national legislatures of the AU member states.
4. The Executive Council, made up of foreign ministers of member states, prepares decisions for the Assembly.
5. The Economic, Social, and Cultural Council (ECOSOCC), a civil society consultative body.

Agenda 2063:

Agenda 2063 is a set of initiatives proposed and currently under implementation by the African Union. It was adopted on 31 January 2015. The stated goals of the agenda are **economic development** (including the eradication of poverty within one generation), **political integration** (in particular through the establishment of a federal or confederate United Africa), **improvements in democracy and justice**, establishment of security and peace on the entire African continent, strengthening of cultural identity through an "African renaissance" and pan-African ideals, gender equality, and political independence from foreign powers.

AfCFTA

The African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) is a free trade area founded in 2018, with trade commencing as of 1 January 2021. It was created by the African Continental Free Trade Agreement among 54 of the 55 African Union nations. The free-trade area is the largest in the

world in terms of the number of participating countries since the formation of the World Trade Organization.

India- Africa Relations

During struggle for independence, India always advocated for anti-colonialism and anti-imperialism in Africa. After Independence India took up the cause of decolonisation of African continent through the platform of Afro Asian Summit, Bandung Declaration of 1955 and NAM. End of racial struggle and decolonization became the rallying point of India–Africa relations.

However the relationship suffered because of instability in the African continent and India's focus on protectionism and import substitution. Since the beginning of 21st century, the relationship has grown by leaps and bounds across multiple sectors like economy, security, capacity building, tackling climate change etc.

Economic Relations:

- India's economic relations with Africa are truly multi-faceted, with the Indian Government extending timely grant-in aid to African countries, concessional lines of credit (LOCs), capacity building and technical assistance, supporting major projects in Africa, establishment of industrial units, among others.
- The India-Africa bilateral trade has been growing steadily, year-on-year, with the trade volume touching almost $100 billion in 2022-23, and aims to double it to $200 billion by 2030. India is the fifth largest investor in Africa with cumulative investments of **$ 54 billion**.
- Bilateral trade is almost balanced with exports being US$ 51.2 Billion and imports being US$ 46.65 Billion in FY 2022-23.
- India has also signed bilateral trade agreements with more than 20 African countries.
- Africa has been one of the largest beneficiaries of Government of India's LOCs that currently amount to more than US$ 6.3 billion out of an overall commitment of US$ 10 billion.
- India's Duty-Free Tariff Preference Scheme (DFTP) for Least Developed Countries (LDCs) has benefitted 38 African countries and contributed to the expansion of India-Africa bilateral trade,
- In pursuance of trilateral cooperation with Africa, India is collaborating with Japan and Kenya to build a cancer hospital and is collaborating with UAE to set up a centre of IT Excellence in Ethiopia.

Political Engagements:

- India has setup **India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS)** as a dedicated platform for engagement between Ina and African nations. Both India and Africa have aligned with each other on the platforms like Climate Change Nnegotiations, UNSC reforms and WTO.
- Over the last five years, India's top leaders have made 34 visits to African nations, and India had hosted nearly 100 African leaders for diverse bilateral and multilateral engagements.
- The Government of India identified 18 African countries including Burkina Faso, Cameroon, Cape Verde, Rwanda, Somalia, among others where new missions would be opened. This will result in Indian missions in 47 out of 54 countries.
- At the recently held G20 summit in India, African Union was made a permanent member of G20.

Security Cooperation:

- In the post-colonial Africa India had assisted to set up military academy in Ethiopia, defence college and Naval war college in Nigeria besides setting up air force in Ghana and training military personnel in number of African countries.
- India have had defence partnerships with Zambia, Nigeria, Ghana, Ethiopia. Botswana, Uganda, Namibia and Mozambique and is seeking to expand this to include more countries across the vast continent.
- India has coastal surveillance radar networks along Madagascar, Mauritius and Seychelles.
- East African nations share boundary with Indo-Pacific region and are key to augmenting India's strategy with respect to maritime security. East African nations form a critical part of India's Indo-Pacific strategy with India having signed multiple defence, trade and shipping agreements over the last few years.
- India is one of the largest contributors to peacekeeping in Africa and has participated in all the UN peacekeeping missions in Africa
- India has also built up its credentials as the first responder as in times of crisis in the Indian Ocean region.
- The first-ever India Africa Defence Ministers Conclave (IADMC) was held in Lucknow in conjunction with DefExpo in 2020. The dialogue will be conducted alongside every defence Expo. During the expo, both sides recognised the common security challenges such as terrorism and extremism, piracy, organised crime including human trafficking, drug trafficking, weapon smuggling and others and agreed to collaborate to tackle them together.
- AFINDEX- Africa India joint exercise. In its second edition in 2023, India reiterated its commitment to providing support to African partner-countries in all defence related matters—including capability enhancement of their Armed Forces—to ensure their economic growth and social development.

Energy Cooperation:

- India imports around 15% of its energy needs from Africa. Energy cooperation is also a key subset of India's development partnership with Africa. Under the International Solar Alliance (ISA) a sizeable share of India's concessional credit has been earmarked to Africa.
- Africa is an important component of One Sun One World One Grid project under International Solar Alliance.
- India and Morocco will explore joint electrification projects in Africa.

Diaspora Relations:

There is More than 3,000,000 people of Indian descendants in Africa. Indian Diaspora in Africa constitutes 12.37 per cent of the total Diaspora of India. A large chunk of Indian diaspora continues to live in African countries such as Kenya, Uganda, Mauritius, and Nigeria.

- India is also seeking to reinvigorate its cultural links with East Africa under the rubric of Project 'Mausam', an initiative of the Ministry of Culture.

Education and Capacity Building:

- India is investing in capacity building providing more than $1 billion in technical assistance and training to personnel under the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC)program.
- India has invested **$100 million** in the Pan-African E-Network to bridge the digital divide in Africa, leveraging its strengths in information technology.
- India is also helping Africa to bridge the digital divide through the 2nd phase of the pan-Africa e-Network project – e-VidyaBharati and e-ArogyaBharati Network Project, which aims to provide 5-years free tele-education to 4,000 students, free medical education to 1,000 doctors/nurses/paramedics and free medical consultancy.
- Solar Mamas trained at Barefoot college in Rajasthan and playing key role in solarisation of Africa.

Developmental Initiatives:

- India has executed 194 developmental projects in 37 African countries and is currently working to complete 77 more projects in 29 countries in the continent, with a total outlay of USD 11.6 billion.
- India and Japan have jointly launched Asian Africa Growth Corridor to boost connectivity in Asia and Africa and compete against China's BRI.
- The India- EU connectivity partnership includes Africa as an area of collaboration with a value-based approach.

India Africa Forum Summit:

The India–Africa Forum Summit (IAFS) is the official platform for the African-Indian relations. IAFS will be held once in every three years. First Summit- 2008, Second Summit- 2011, Third Summit- 2015.

Third summit was the largest-ever turnout of African leaders in India. Leadership from all 54 African nations were present. The fourth summit has been postponed due to Covid-19 pandemic.

Assistance during Covid-19:

Under India's landmark **'Vaccine Maitri'** initiative, India gifted 150 metric tonnes of medical supplies to 25 African countries. In addition, India supplied 25 million doses of vaccines that were produced within the country to 42 countries in the African region.

India's Approach towards Africa: Outlined at a speech in Ugandan Parliament by PM Modi.

1. Africa will be at the top of our priorities. We will continue to intensify and deepen our engagement with Africa. As we have shown, it will be sustained and regular.
2. Our development partnership will be guided by your priorities. We will build as much local capacity and create local opportunities as possible. It will be on terms that are comfortable to you, that will liberate your potential and not constrain your future.
3. We will keep our markets open and make it easier and more attractive to trade with India. We will support our industry to invest in Africa.
4. We will harness India's experience with the digital revolution to support Africa's development; improve delivery of public services; extend education and health; spread digital literacy; expand financial inclusion; and mainstream the marginalised.
5. Africa has 60 percent of the world's arable land, but produces just 10 percent of the global output. We will work with you to improve Africa's agriculture.
6. Our partnership will address the challenges of climate change.
7. We will strengthen our cooperation and mutual capabilities in combating terrorism and extremism; keeping our cyberspace safe and secure; and, supporting the UN in advancing and keeping peace.
8. We will work with African nations to keep the oceans open and free for the benefit of all nations. The world needs cooperation and competition in the eastern shores of Africa and the eastern Indian Ocean.
9. As global engagement in Africa increases, we must all work together to ensure that Africa does not once again turn into a theatre of rival ambitions, but becomes a nursery for the aspirations of Africa's youth.
10. Just as India and Africa fought colonialism together, we will work together for a just, representative and democratic global order that has a voice for one-third of humanity that lives in Africa and India.

Challenges:

1. Limited economic muscle, delay in project execution leads to mistrust about Indian commitments.
2. Lack of any grand strategy or dedicated policy in engagement with Africa.

3. Disconnect between India's development assistance to Africa and economic engagement with the continent.
4. India's development funds are channelized through African Union without significant role of Indian embassies in respective countries.
5. Mistreatment of African students and visitors in India generates animosity within African society.
6. Indian projects face challenge not only from China, but also from Europe and USA.
7. No project has been announced under Asia Africa growth corridor, seen as an alternative to BRI.
8. Lack of regular engagements. IAFS meetings have been too few and irregularly.

Report on Africa by Vivekananda International Foundation

The 20-member **Africa Expert Group (AEG)**, established by the **Vivekananda International Foundation (VIF)**, recently presented the Report entitled **'India-Africa Partnership: Achievements, Challenges and Roadmap 2023'**

- It states that Africa is slowly **heading toward regional integration** and is devoted to **democracy, peace and progress.**
- **It has portrayed** China's role as **'the infrastructure developer', 'the resource provider'**, and **'the financier**' to the region.

Recommendations:

- **Political and diplomatic cooperation:** Political and diplomatic cooperation should be strengthened by restoring periodic leaders' summits through the **medium of the India-Africa Forum Summit**; the last summit was in 2015.
- **Dialogue with African Union (AU):** Besides, a new annual strategic dialogue between the chairperson of the **African Union (AU)** and India's External Affairs Minister should be launched in 2023.
- **AU's entry into the G-20:** Another recommendation relates to forging consensus among G-20 members on the **AU's entry into the G-20 as a full member**.
- **Defence and security cooperation:** The government needs to increase the number of **defence attachés deployed in Africa**, expand dialogue on defence issues, and expand lines of credit to facilitate defence exports.
- **Economic and development cooperation:** India-Africa trade touching $98 billion in FY22–23 is an encouraging development. But it can go up if access to finance through the **creation of an Africa Growth Fund (AGF)** is ensured.
- **Socio-cultural cooperation:** Socio-cultural cooperation should be increased through g**reater interaction** between universities, think tanks, civil society and media organisations in India and select African countries, **Visa measures for African students** who come to India for higher education should be liberalised and they **should also be given work visas** for short periods.

China in Africa

1. China is Africa's largest trade partner with bilateral trade more than $254 billion. It is 4th largest investor with total investment of $43 billion.
2. Total Chinese loan to Africa is more than $148 billion, making it single largest creditor to Africa.
3. China's first overseas military base is Djibouti, in the horn of Africa.
4. 39 countries from Africa support the BRI, with mostly coastal nations.
5. Since 2009, China has overtaken the United States as Africa's largest trade partner, bilateral trade between the two topping $254 billion as of 2021.

Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC)- Held regularly every three years. Til now, eight summits have taken place, latest one in 2021.

Security Cooperation:

1. China supports Africa's military transformation by providing equipment, advanced technology, and independent capacity-building.
2. The "China-Africa Defence and Security Forum" is an important development in this context as it is promises to be a major ideation forum.

Challenges:

1. The unilateral nature of the initiative, the lack of transparency and accountability to African countries, and the absence of projects that directly benefit locals have raised suspicions and fuelled local resentment.
2. Frequent local protests and harassing and kidnapping of Chinese workers in countries like Nigeria, Uganda and Tanzania.

India Vs. China in Africa

1. At 3rd IAFS, India offered $10 billion investment, while at the 2018 Forum for China–Africa Cooperation in Beijing, China offered Africa $60 billion for development financing until 2021.
2. Because of the social capital India has in Africa, its presence is welcomed by African countries in a way that China's is not.
3. China goes for large infrastructure projects while India is mainly focussed on HICDPs and capacity building initiatives.
4. Chinese projects are extractive and strategically located while India's projects are as per needs of respective countries and funds are handled by African Union.
5. Some of Indian initiatives like Solar Mamas have been globally acknowledged.

Suggestions:

1. To overcome the China challenge in Africa, increased cooperation between India and its international allies should be priority. The recent India-EU Summit has identified Africa as a region where a partnership-based approach will be followed.

2. The fourth summit, pending since last year, should be held as soon as possible, even if in a virtual format.
3. Rather than playing catch-up with China, India should leverage its own unique strength in areas like capacity building, entrepreneurship, MSME etc.
4. Undertake projects under AAGC and synergise between Act East and PQI.
5. Take direct control of development programme by involving respective missions, rather than handing it to AU intermediaries.
6. Disburse aid bilaterally and align it to national priorities of respective states to make them stakeholders.